

Cross-site scripting

Cross-site scripting (XSS) accounts of nearly 80% of all security vulnerabilities according to a Symantec story in 2007

Open Web Application Security Project

The OWASP community releases numerous tools and even an entire Linux distro aimed at testing the security of web applications

A look at modern browser security features

Most browser vulnerabilities are due to the problem that exists between the keyboard and the chair. There is no patch for that yet

Kshitij Sobti

kshitij.sobti@thinkdigit.com

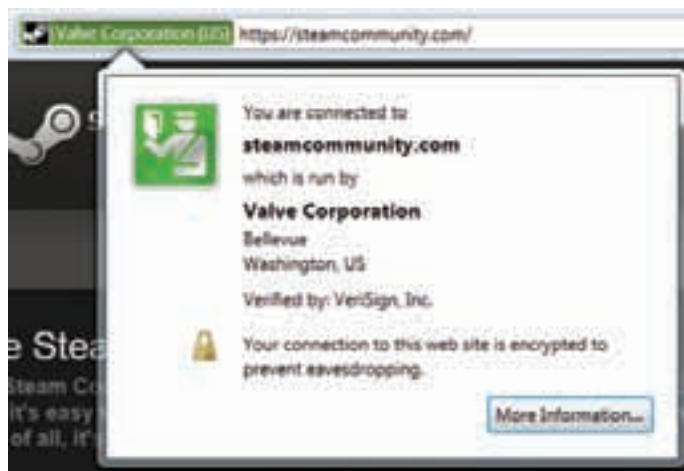
As a greater part of our lives start involving computers, and more so the internet, it becomes clear that there is a lot of information at stake. One can today buy items online using a variety of payment systems, all of which hinge on a few protection factors (a few numbers, a user name and password etc.) that can easily be captured.

No matter what browsers vendors do in securing their browsers, and web sites do in securing their infrastructure and code, more often than not, the end-user is the source of the gravest vulnerabilities. Whether one is vulnerable to pornography, or photos of cute kittens playing with string, chances are that the end-user initiated the action that has left their computer attacked.

As a result, a large number of the features that are being introduced in newer browsers are those that protect users from their own mistakes, rather than countering technical errors. Let us take a look at some of the ways modern browsers are protecting users from the internet and themselves.

Enhanced address bars

The browser address bar is a perfect example. Despite wide promotion, people rarely confirm the identity and security of the web sites they visit. Browsers have thus added visual indicators of the security of the connection and authenticity of



The Opera and Firefox both use similar means to convey security status

the web site. This may be trivial, but URLs are an important part of the web, and thus, so are address bars.

All browsers have slightly different ways of displaying this information, but all of them try to make such information as clear as possible. All browsers have some form of security / authority badge that can be clicked to reveal more information about the connection / web site.

Private browsing

Private browsing may have been invented for "love-struck fiancées shopping for

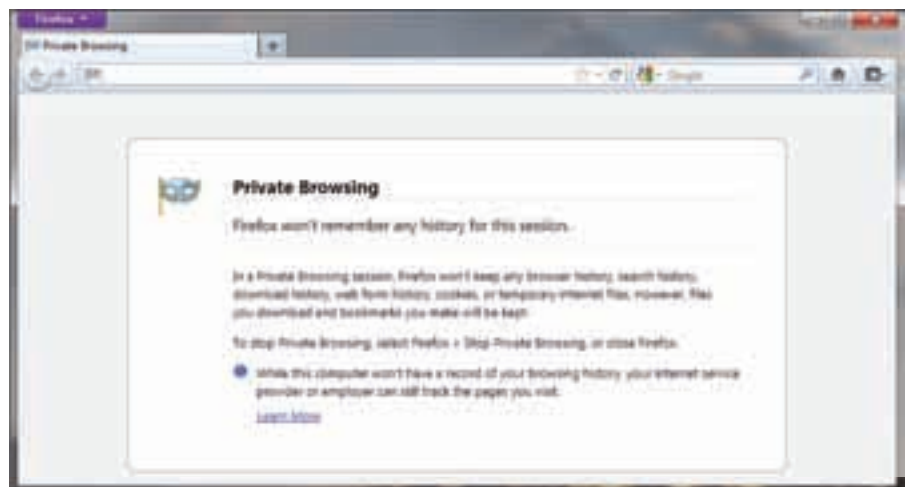
engagement rings" online, however it is a good security feature as well. It is of great benefit while using web sites that need extra security (bank web sites and PayPal) or a public computer.

In private browsing mode, the browser does not record any of your activities while you

are using it. Google Chrome even disables extensions – unless you specifically allow them – in this mode, thus plugging any sources of leak of data. All browsers support this in slightly different ways. IE and Chrome can open private windows, Opera can even open private tabs, while Firefox and Safari can work in either private or normal mode.

Phishing and malware protection

As an internet citizen, you may be wondering, "how is phishing and malware my fault!"



Private mode in Firefox